

Pakistan’s militants wielding U.S. arms

Weapons left behind in Afghanistan give fighters edge over security forces

BY RICK NOACK, ALEX HORTON, HAQ NAWAZ KHAN AND SHAIQ HUSSAIN

PESHAWAR, PAKISTAN — On Jan. 9, 2018, an M4A1 carbine rifle left the Colt’s Manufacturing plant in Connecticut, bound for Afghanistan. Last month, it was recovered in the aftermath of a deadly train hijacking by militants in Pakistan.

The banged-up rifle, bearing serial number W1004340 and stamped with the Colt logo, was among billions of dollars’ worth of U.S. military equipment provided to Afghan forces, much of which was abandoned after the withdrawal of American troops in 2021.

Many of the weapons wound up across the border in Pakistan, at arms bazaars and in the hands of insurgents, illustrating how the consequences of America’s failed war continue to reverberate years after the fall of Kabul to the Taliban.

After a decade of progress against militants, Pakistan is now struggling to contain multiple insurgencies — from jihadists in the north to Baloch separatists in the southwest — fueled in part by American weapons.

U.S. assault rifles, machine guns and night-vision goggles, originally meant to help stabilize Afghanistan, are now being used by the Pakistani Taliban (TTP)

SEE WEAPONS ON A11

Man charged in governor’s mansion fire denied bail

Suspect said he planned to beat Pa.’s Shapiro with hammer, police say

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND AMBER FERGUSON

The man charged with setting fire to the official residence of Pennsylvania Gov. Josh Shapiro (D) told authorities he walked more than an hour from his home, carrying beer bottles filled with gasoline, before scaling a fence, breaking into the mansion and setting a room ablaze.

Police have accused 38-year-old Cody Balmer, of Harrisburg, of seeking to harm Shapiro — he allegedly told police he planned to beat the governor with a hammer if he encountered him — and his family as they slept upstairs. He was denied bail at an arraignment Monday and did not enter a plea.

The attack is the most recent on an elected U.S. official since last year’s apparent assassination attempts on now-President Donald Trump while he campaigned. There have been several instances of attempted violence against politicians of both parties in recent years, including a kidnapping plot against Michigan Gov. Gretchen Whitmer (D), a hammer attack on Democratic Rep. Nancy Pelosi’s husband and an attempted assault

SEE ARSON ON A2



ALLISON JOYCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Walker Sides, left, and Billy Callis at Hickory Nut Gap Farm, which is dealing with the uncertainty of Donald Trump’s tariffs.

Tariffs grow uncertainty for farmers

Trump’s levies threaten to sow a rift with a key constituency in North Carolina, a swing state

BY CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

FAIRVIEW, N.C. — For John Ashe, the start of growing season is always a math problem, a complex calculus of educated guesses as he tries to extract every cent from his farm in Reidsville, near the Virginia-North Carolina border.

The 57-year-old has been farming all his life. Every year, he mulls changes recommended by the tobacco companies, considers competition from Brazilian soybean farmers and ponders how much labor he needs to hire to eke out enough profit to keep everything going.

But this year, his biggest numbers

challenge has been the tariff policies of President Donald Trump.

“It’s always been a guessing game here on the farm, but I think it’s more of a guess now than it’s ever been in my lifetime,” Ashe said on Wednesday, as he alternated between trimming tobacco seedlings in his greenhouse and checking his phone for tariff updates.

The plants will go in the ground this month, but his anxieties center on his soon-to-be-sown crop of soybeans. Most years, a large portion of his harvest would be exported to China, which is the top target in an escalating trade war started by the president.

“I don’t really understand how [Trump]

feels like he can do this all across the country,” said Ashe, who voted against Trump in the past three presidential elections. He scoffed at the president’s admonition that Americans “Be Strong, Courageous, and Patient.”

“This is not a thing where we can wait three months,” Ashe said. “This is a critical time. It’s going to be critical until harvest. It’s amazing to me how some farmers are still proud of him for doing this.”

Midway through the spring planting season, farmers in a state whose electoral votes went to Trump in the past three elections are struggling with the unpre-

SEE FARMERS ON A18

Gold rush: The precious metal is having a moment as nervous investors seek financial safe havens. A6



ZHANG LANG/CHINA NEWS SERVICE/VCG/GETTY IMAGES

Beijing targets increasing obesity

BY LYRIC LI

Across China, authorities are busting their humps trying to get people to shrink their waistslines.

They’re promoting lite menus, tweaked for regional tastes. They’ve released weight-management-themed emoji for messaging apps. Neighborhood officials and surveillance volunteers have been enlisted to go door to door to educate residents on the health risks of obesity. Hotels are even installing scales in rooms to en-

With over half of Chinese considered heavy, top officials launch 3-year offensive

A gym teacher instructs students at a fat-burning boot camp at a Xinchuan Foreign Language School in Chengdu. Obesity is a relatively new problem in a nation that once struggled to feed its people.

courage travelers — and businessmen in particular — to pay attention to their pounds.

Local government officials in Guangdong, a province of 127 million that’s home to manufacturing and tech giants, are urging companies to implement mandatory workout breaks, set up sports teams and find ways to motivate employees to keep fit.

And the Southern University of Science and Technology in Shenzhen has launched a competition

SEE CHINA ON A8

Plan would nearly halve budget for State Dept.

Memo outlines dramatic cuts to funding for U.N., global health and more

BY ADAM TAYLOR AND JOHN HUDSON

The Trump administration proposed cutting the budget of the State Department and what remains of the U.S. Agency for International Development by almost half, according to an internal memo circulated last week, with funds for humanitarian assistance, global health and international organizations facing dramatic reductions.

The memo, which was reviewed by The Washington Post, says that cuts contained in an early proposal from the White House Office of Management and Budget for the next fiscal year would leave a total budget of \$28.4 billion for all activities carried out by the State Department and USAID, a separate agency that the Trump administration has sought to dismantle. That represents a decline of \$27 billion, or 48 percent, from funding levels approved by Congress for 2025.

Under the proposed budget described in the memo, which remains subject to deliberations within the administration and, crucially, on Capitol Hill, USAID is assumed to have become fully a

part of the State Department. Humanitarian assistance would face cuts of 54 percent, while global health funding would fall by 55 percent, the memo says.

There would be particularly steep cuts to support for international organizations, with just under 90 percent of this funding eliminated in the proposal. Funding for the United Nations, NATO and 20 other organizations would be ended, the memo states, while targeted contributions to a handful of organizations, including the International Atomic Energy Agency and the International Civil Aviation Authority, would remain. The memo also describes a total cut in funding for international peacekeeping missions, citing “recent mission failures” without providing details.

It is unclear whether such steep cuts, as outlined in the memo, would secure approval in the Republican-controlled Congress. President Donald Trump’s aggressive bid to cut government spending and drastically reduce the federal workforce, including through the work of tech billionaire Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service, which led the dismantling of USAID, has faced strident opposition in some GOP districts, though few

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Financial aid: Staff reductions hinder help for students. A3

USAID: Official who oversaw cuts at agency leaves State Dept. A6

SALVADORAN LEADER VISITS OVAL OFFICE

Trump floats deporting criminal U.S. citizens

BY DAN DIAMOND AND CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

Salvadoran President Nayib Bukele said Monday that he does not plan to return a Maryland man whom the Trump administration mistakenly deported to his country, as the U.S. judicial system barrels toward a potential constitutional crisis over the standoff.

“How can I return him to the United States?” Bukele said in an Oval Office meeting with President Donald Trump, responding to a reporter’s question.



Abrego García

“I smuggle him into the United States? Of course I’m not going to do it. The question is preposterous. How can I smuggle a terrorist into the United States?”

Kilmar Abrego García, a Salvadoran immigrant who is married to a U.S. citizen, was deported last month to El Salvador’s brutal mega-prison, CECOT. His case has become a focal point of the Trump administration’s attempt to deport more than 1 million immigrants from the United States — and the court battles over the legality of that campaign.

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An invitation: Zelensky urges Trump to visit war-torn Ukraine. A11

IN THE NEWS

Fears for their new home Immigrants who left authoritarian nations to build new lives in the U.S. now see democratic norms eroding in their adopted country. A10

Religious rectification After a century, two Jewish soldiers got tombstones with Stars of David at Arlington National Cemetery. B1

THE NATION After Harvard rejected demands for major changes, Trump officials froze funding. A4 The pick for a top health post said trans youths should undergo “corrective care.” A5

THE WORLD Chinese leader Xi Jinping visited Vietnam, promising “stability” amid a tariff war. A7 Thousands of Israeli reservists have condemned the return to war in Gaza. A12

THE ECONOMY Investor and podcast host David Sacks has been driving U.S. tech policy as AI and crypto czar. A13 Tariffs on active pharmaceutical ingredients from China could disrupt the supply of heparin, a widely used medication. A14

THE REGION The D.C. government, still in limbo over the 2025 budget, may try to cover part of the fiscal gap created by Congress via a 2009 law. B1 The long-awaited Cedar Hill hospital opened, fulfilling part of the mayor’s health-care initiative in Wards 7 and 8. B1

STYLE A closer look at the all-women Blue Origin spaceflight, tears and all. C1 HEALTH & SCIENCE Dementia and grief altered the relationship between a Post journalist and her stepfather, who lives in a memory-care facility. E1

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